

KERALA: Basheer A., 39, *B.Sc. (Agriculture)*

Job applied for: Forest watcher, Kottayam district

Total vacancies: 12; Total applications: 2,700

A. Basheer, from Poovar, a tourist village at the edge of Kerala, has been trying for a government job for 18 years. After a B.Com. degree, he has appeared multiple times in the examinations held by the Kerala Public Service Commission, the agency that handles public recruitments in the state. In 2018, he was ranked 187th in the list for the 400-odd posts for forest watchers in Kottayam district. But the PSC gave appointment advice memos to only three people in the merit list. The remaining posts were filled with temporary appointees. Basheer approached the Kerala High Court against the appointment of temporary forest watchers for the existing vacancies despite the valid merit list. The case is pending before the court.

"I was anticipating that I would get this post as around 400 vacancies were listed," says Basheer. But barring three posts, the rest were filled by temps recommended by politicians or senior officials. "We protested for 63 days, but the government ignored us. So, we moved court," says Basheer, who is also the general secretary of the Kerala PSC Rank Holders' Association. He alleges that government departments hide details of vacancies so that they can appoint temporary workers and regularise them after 10 years. Basheer, meanwhile, has been running an internet cafe to support his wife and six-year-old daughter.

"HIRING 1 LAKH PEOPLE WILL COST MY GOVERNMENT AROUND Rs 200 CRORE. I'LL HAVE TO REDUCE CAPITAL AND REVENUE EXPENDITURE, THOUGH THE ADDED MANPOWER WILL BENEFIT THE STATE IN THE LONG RUN"

HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
Chief Minister, Assam



Modi had promised 20 million jobs every year in 2014, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee spoke of 15 million new jobs in 2021. Budget 2022 chose a humbler target: six million over the next five years. That there's never any reliable data to verify the fulfilment of such promises does not deter parties—indeed, it perhaps encourages them. "During its UP campaign, the Congress promised a timeline of six months for all recruitments. Have they been able to do it in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh?" asks Anupam. The scarcity breeds the opacity: nobody has much clarity on the numbers. The Bihar violence framed a dark irony here. Just three years ago, then Union finance minister Arun Jaitley had stated that the absence of social agitations for jobs in the preceding five years was evidence that jobs were being created.

How many jobs are there, really?

Fact is, between 2014 and 2020, exactly 398,459 new positions were added to the sanctioned strength of central government jobs. A growth rate of 11 per cent, which took the overall central workforce to just over 4 million. Sounds impressive, till you contrast it with the fact that vacancies doubled in that period—from 421,658 to 872,243. Hiring has been painfully slow: the central government has made only 444,813 hirings, half of what it could, in the past five years. Nearly 30 per cent of these happened because of a railway recruitment drive in 2019-20—the Indian Railways is the biggest